

Checklist

Manager Checklist

Starting with a new report

- ☐ Learn the person's preferences for praise: public or private
- ☐ Ask how they prefer to receive serious feedback
- ☐ Ask what excited them to join and why they chose the company
- ☐ Ask how to recognize when they are stressed, frustrated, or in a bad mood
- ☐ Ask which manager behaviors they dislike
- ☐ Ask about their career goals
- ☐ Ask about any surprises, concerns, or unmet expectations since joining
- ☐ Build trust and rapport early
- ☐ Create a 30/60/90-day plan together
- ☐ Make expectations clear: communication, meeting cadence, work style, escalation, and autonomy
- ☐ Get feedback from the new hire during the first 90 days
- ☐ Involve them in improving onboarding documentation

Running 1:1s well

- ☐ Set up regular 1:1s
- ☐ Default to weekly 1:1s unless there is a good reason not to
- ☐ Reschedule missed 1:1s rather than skipping them
- ☐ Choose times that work for both schedules and minimize disruption
- ☐ Adjust frequency based on need, not habit
- ☐ Keep doing 1:1s even with strong performers
- ☐ Use 1:1s for more than status updates
- ☐ Leave room to get to know the person as a human being
- ☐ Keep shared notes from each 1:1

Adapting 1:1 style

- ☐ Decide whether this person needs a to-do list style, catch-up style, feedback style, or progress-report style 1:1

- ☐ Make sure the meeting serves the report, not just the manager
- ☐ Avoid letting 1:1s turn into repeated complaint sessions
- ☐ Give space for the important topics the report wants to raise
- ☐ Mix formats when useful, but protect privacy for sensitive discussions

Giving feedback continuously

- ☐ Learn each person's strengths, weaknesses, goals, and current level
- ☐ Observe people closely enough to notice patterns
- ☐ Start with lightweight, regular feedback
- ☐ Give praise promptly and specifically
- ☐ Give corrective feedback as soon as possible
- ☐ Do not save important feedback for a formal review
- ☐ Pair feedback with coaching when appropriate
- ☐ Focus on helping people grow, not just judging them
- ☐ Make frequent feedback part of team culture

Developing people

- ☐ Help each person identify areas for learning and growth
- ☐ Support growth through projects, mentoring, and external learning
- ☐ Discuss career development regularly, not just during reviews
- ☐ Look for promotion-ready opportunities and stretch work
- ☐ Be transparent about how promotion works at your company
- ☐ Help people build a case for promotion when they are ready

Delegating without micromanaging

- ☐ Delegate ownership, not just tasks
- ☐ Stay involved enough to support success without taking over
- ☐ Use team goals to decide which details matter
- ☐ Ask teams to make progress and success measures visible
- ☐ Pull information from systems first before asking people for updates
- ☐ Avoid asking for information you could easily get yourself
- ☐ Adjust your level of involvement based on project stage and risk
- ☐ Set standards for code, systems, and decision-making
- ☐ Treat open sharing of problems neutrally and constructively
- ☐ Protect autonomy because autonomy drives motivation

Performance reviews

- ☐ Start early and give yourself enough uninterrupted time
- ☐ Review the whole year, not just recent months
- ☐ Keep notes throughout the year to support review writing
- ☐ Use concrete examples
- ☐ Incorporate peer feedback thoughtfully
- ☐ Spend real time on accomplishments and strengths
- ☐ Keep areas for improvement focused and clear
- ☐ Avoid big surprises in formal reviews
- ☐ Give the person time to read the review before discussing it
- ☐ Discuss the review in enough depth to be useful

Handling underperformance

- ☐ Address problems early
- ☐ Follow the rule of “no surprises.”
- ☐ Be clear about what good performance looks like
- ☐ Tell the person early and often when they are not meeting expectations
- ☐ Document negative feedback and improvement expectations
- ☐ Put timelines and concrete deliverables in writing when needed
- ☐ Work with HR processes where required
- ☐ Do not wait until frustration boils over
- ☐ Be fair, direct, and specific
- ☐ Do not put someone on a plan unless you are prepared for them to leave

Coaching someone out

- ☐ Be honest when someone is not progressing to the next level on your team
- ☐ Explain clearly what the next level requires
- ☐ Say directly when the team may not be the right place for that growth
- ☐ Help them explore a better-fit role internally or externally
- ☐ Preserve goodwill and dignity

Self-check

- ☐ Do I hold regular 1:1s?
- ☐ Have I discussed career development recently?
- ☐ Have I given feedback in the last week?

- ☐ Have I recognized good work publicly or privately?
- ☐ Have I corrected issues promptly and appropriately?
- ☐ Do I understand how promotions work here?
- ☐ Am I delegating well instead of micromanaging?
- ☐ Am I helping people grow, not just evaluating them?